

Future Media Delivery

The 5th Axis

Who decided and why?

Valentijn Siebrands | Future Media Townhall

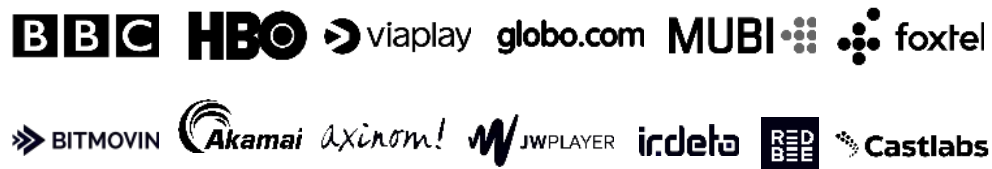
IBC 2026



Built in Amsterdam, trusted globally

Developing innovations in video streaming technology

We serve 140+ clients and collaborate with 50+ partners worldwide.



10+ years
in the industry

HQ Amsterdam,
Netherlands

Defining standards and specs that advance the industry

We work closely with the biggest, best-known organizations.



What's changing in Media Delivery?

At EBU Horizons '26, Antonio Arcidiacono, EBU Director of Technology & Innovation, said:

AI will move the center of gravity of media from centralized cloud platforms to intelligent devices at the edge. Whoever controls distribution and the user interface controls the next media economy.

Instead of broadcasting one piece of content to millions of people, the same underlying content gets transformed locally -an essay, a podcast, an image- a dialogue tailored to each user.

HORIZONS AN EBU EVENT

EBU

The Great Network Shift: From Transport to Intelligence

Yesterday's Network: The Transport Era	Tomorrow's Network: The Inference-First Era
Purpose: Connecting people and moving data.	Purpose: Enabling AI agents to compute, decide, and act.
Dominant Traffic: Human communication and video streaming (>75 % of volume).	Dominant Traffic: Machine-to-machine communication, tiny prompts, and context updates.
Value Proposition Speed and bandwidth (Gbps).	Value Proposition Inference continuity and resilience.

The Paradigm Shift

The network's primary role is evolving from transporting massive video streams to enabling local AI generation.

A 2 KB prompt can create a 200 MB video at the edge, fundamentally changing traffic patterns and network requirements where resilience becomes the most critical, *exitelua*.

© Antonio Arcidiacono - March 2026

My take: I build the pipes that carry this. Antonio's right: a 20-word prompt generates a 200 MB video, on-device, maybe by next year.

AI becomes the intermediary between content and consumer. The broadcaster stops being the last editorial checkpoint.

But are we ready for this?

WHERE WE STARTED....

Before there were platforms, there were **editors**

Then:

- A name on the masthead
- Someone who could be asked, “Why did you run this story?”
- A person could be named and held accountable

Now:

- TikTok, YouTube, LinkedIn, Instagram
- Automated power over what billions see
- No name, no byline, no person to ask, “Why?”

Somewhere between the editorial desk and the algorithm, the accountable decisionmaker that we trusted disappeared. We barely noticed it.

IN THE 90s AN ASSUMPTION WAS SET

Two US court cases one an odd outcome

1991: CompuServe

- Hosts forums and bulletin boards.
Reviews nothing. Someone got defamed

Court ruling: It's a shelf, a bookstore,
CompuServe didn't look. **It isn't liable**

1995: Prodigy

- Hosts forums, moderates.
Something slipped. Someone got defamed

Court ruling: By moderating, it acted as a
publisher. **It's liable for all it missed**

Mismatch: If you look at content, you own it. Don't look, and you're safe

THE 90's FIX AND WHAT IT ASSUMED

Congress fixed the incentive

Section 230, 1996: Protects online platforms from liability for user-generated content while allowing them to moderate posts in good faith.



*(Europe wrote its own version "**mere conduit**" in the eCommerce Directive, copied largely into the DSA)*

The intermediary is not deciding what you should see, it's *passive*.

WHAT CHANGED?

That assumption is getting old

Platforms no longer do 'look/don't-look': Their algorithms *actively* decide who sees what.

WHAT'S SHOWN FIRST

TO WHOM

WHEN

FOR HOW LONG

PASSIVE? [Gonzalez v. Google \(2023\)](#) was a landmark Supreme Court case that questioned whether tech companies are legally responsible for content pushed by their recommendation algorithms, but the Court ultimately sidestepped a major ruling on tech liability.

So, the 90's assumption survived.

PASSIVE?

'Passive' is happening at every layer, it's everywhere

RECOMMENDATION SYSTEMS

decide what surfaces on the timeline, shelf, triggers

SSAI / SGAI: AD DECISIONING

decide what's inserted, per viewer, per device, per location

PERSONALIZED ASSEMBLY

decides sequence and composition of content: we ship this today

FUTURE: EDGE AI's NEGOTIATING

decides on-device, per household: the vision EBU is pursuing

FUTURE: TRANSPORT RELAYS

hold session state, observe metadata, participate in prioritization

A USEFUL EXAMPLE

Media over QUIC shows it in the open

HTTP DELIVERY REFLECTS THE 90s

request → response → cache → delivery
Largely transports what was requested.
200 OK. 403 Forbidden. 404 Not Found.

RELAYS IN MoQ

Maintain live, per-session state.
Can observe object metadata.
Participate in prioritisation.
React to session and device behaviour.

That doesn't make them bad. It makes them active.

MoQ is still being written, which is exactly why it's the useful example rather than the guilty party. **Every layer is acquiring decision-making at the same time, and none inherited a mechanism for recording why.**

THE FUTURE IS NO LONGER ABOUT JUST DELIVERY

It adds AI agents that...

decide what you watch

select which objects to retrieve and monetize

generate or transform media on the fly

optimize the delivery path

decide which information to use

decide whether you're entitled to access at all

Those aren't transport decisions. **They are *active* decisions about the media experience itself.**

THIS IS ACTUALLY AN ENGINEERING QUESTION

What is it we are actually building?

This isn't just a legal problem.

If the system selects, generates, prioritizes, adapts, and gates media, then **decision-making has become part of the architecture.**

Which means **Accountability** needs to become part of the architecture too.

Not a compliance doc

Not a checkbox

Not an afterthought

A property of the system.

2026 INDICATES A UNIQUE POINT IN TIME

Decentralization is not accountability

APRIL 2026 · FRACTURED REALITY

The European Commission's research arm names *attention-driven algorithms and foreign-controlled infrastructure as structural risks to democracy*.

Its response: transparency, accountability, sovereignty, decentralized 'AI' alternatives.

BUT DISTRIBUTION ≠ ACCOUNTABILITY

AI in the device. AI in the home. AI in the network. A powerful architectural direction.

But if every component can decide, generate, and gate on its own, you multiply decision points, **not accountability.**

So the future question is: How can we trace the decision, the motive and...still trust the outcome?

More decision points is not more accountability. It is only harder to trace.

THE PROPOSAL

Adding a 5th axis for media: **Accountability**

Fifty years of video engineering optimized four dimensions. Previous generations never had to ask: who decided? Why?

DELAY

QUALITY

STORAGE

BANDWIDTH

ACCOUNTABILITY

ATTRIBUTION

Every decision traceable to a named, verifiable agent with an identity

SCOPE

Signals used are declared and bounded, not open-ended, it's regulated

DECISION EVIDENCE

Machine-readable evidence of what was negotiated, who won, and why

PERSISTENCE

Evidence persists from camera to publisher to consumer-agent to you

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE IN PRACTICE

Same content. Same latency. One difference.

A device requests a personalised channel. An agent assembles it: three segments from the catalogue, one ad slot filled by a bid, running order adjusted to that viewer.

TODAY

The stream plays.

Nothing says why those segments, that ad, that order.

WITH THE FIFTH AXIS

Selection made by this agent, using these declared signals. This slot was paid placement from this buyer. The chain proves nothing was altered on the way.

The only difference: someone can ask why, and get an answer.

The mechanisms mostly exist. C2PA does this for media objects. Event messages ride inside CMAF fragments. Object metadata travels in MoQ. **We're not inventing a new layer, we're asking an existing one to carry one more thing.**

THE SUGGESTION FOR THE FUTURE

Shape standards so that we help everyone

Accountability isn't a policy ask, it's an engineering property.

**We let transport go active without asking what it would mean for people.
This time, while we embed AI, let's ask *and decide* for Accountability.**

Let's design and **build it together.**

Let's start the discussion!

valentijn@unified-streaming.com
unified-streaming.com